

made possible depending on the nature of motion and amount of subject magnification. Apart from achieving longer exposures, a less common application is to enable a shallower depth of field in very bright light, yielding dramatic improvements in background blur and subject isolation.



Gradual Neutral Density filters

GND filters

Another hidden secret of successful landscape photographers is the Graduated Neutral Density (GND) or “grad” filters, which serve as an essential tool for capturing scenes with a broad dynamic range. Nowadays the grad ND effect can be applied digitally, either during RAW development or in subsequent photo editing by using multiple exposures and combining them later during editing, yet using the physical filter while clicking pictures will undoubtedly produce a higher quality result, having a huge impact on the eventual picture composition.

The filter is basically an optical device that allows for variable light transmission. Typically half the filter is of neutral density which transitions, either abruptly or gradually, into the other half which is clear. Thus the filter can be ‘hard edged’, causing sudden change in brightness, or be ‘soft edged’, offering smoother changes from light to dark. For situations where an extremely gradual blend is required, an ‘attenuator’ is used, changing density almost throughout the length. In general when using grad ND filters, wider angles of view are often enhanced more, primarily because these encompass a correspondingly greater range of brightness. Graduated ND filters affect two aspects of a photograph- the dynamic range and the local contrast. You can thus capture a scene whose range of brightness exceeds the capabilities of your camera, and even though such filters usually decrease the contrast between extreme light and dark regions, the contrast within each region actually increases, thereby improving appearance of colour and details. Their effect is usually determined by the strength of the grad ND, referring to the difference between reduction of light on one side of the gradient as compared to the other, and also on the rate of transition, referring to the rate at which the darkest side of the filter merges with the clearer side.